

Believe Into Him

The Verb That English Broke

There is a debate that has run through the church for centuries, and you have probably heard it argued in living rooms and pulpits alike. One side says salvation is by faith alone, that believing Christ died for our sins is everything and works add nothing. The other side answers that mere belief cannot be enough, because even a hypocrite can believe, and faith without works is dead. So the argument rages on, as it has since the Reformation and before.

But here is something worth considering before taking a side: the debate, as we usually hear it, is being conducted in English. And English is quietly sabotaging both sides. Because the English word "believe" no longer means what the biblical words mean. In modern English, to believe something is passive and noncommittal. I believe it will rain tomorrow. I believe the store closes at nine. It is an opinion held in an armchair, requiring nothing of me, changing nothing about me. If that is what "believe" means, then of course the debate is stuck, because everyone can feel that armchair opinion cannot be the hinge of eternity.

Scripture never asks for that. The words the biblical authors actually chose, in Hebrew and in Greek, describe something you do with your whole weight. And when you recover those words, the ancient debate does not so much get settled as get exposed: both sides were often arguing about a word the Bible never used.

So let us go find the real words.

The Greek: A Word From the Vocabulary of Trust

The New Testament word behind every "believe" is the verb πιστεύω, *pisteuō*. Every "he who believeth" in the old translations is the participle *ho pisteuōn*, "the believing one." The noun is *pistis*, faith; the adjective is *pistos*, faithful, trustworthy. One root runs through all of them, and its core meaning in ordinary Greek was never "to hold an opinion." It meant to place trust in, to rely upon, to be persuaded to the point of commitment. In everyday Greek life you would *pisteuō* a bank with your money or entrust a friend with your life. This is the vocabulary of entrustment, not of mental assent.

Notice what that means: in the language of the New Testament, there is no separate everyday word for "trust," because *pisteuō* is the trust word. What English splits into two ideas, "believe" for the head and "trust" for the heart, Greek holds together as a single act.

Scripture does have neighboring words. There is *peithō*, whose perfect form describes settled confidence, the word used when Jesus speaks of those who trust in riches (Mark 10:24). There is *elpizō*, to hope in. But wherever salvation is at stake, the word is *pisteuō*, the entrusting word.

Believe Into: The Grammar Guard

The New Testament writers seem to have known that passive belief was a danger, because they built a grammatical guard against it, and this may be the most beautiful detail in the whole study.

The Apostle John's favorite construction is *pisteuō eis*: literally, "believe INTO" him. "Whoever believes into him should not perish but have eternal life" (John 3:16). "Believe into the light, that you may become sons of light" (John 12:36). Classical Greek did not talk this way. You could believe *that* a statement was true, or believe a person's word, but believing *into* a person was essentially a Christian coinage, a phrase the church had to invent because no existing Greek expression said what needed saying.

And feel what the preposition does. You can believe *that* something is true from your armchair. You cannot believe *into* someone without moving. The phrase is directional, like falling into someone's arms. It describes a transfer of location, out of yourself and into Christ. Belief that is information. Belief into is motion.

James exploits exactly this gap in his famous, uncomfortable verse: "You believe that God is one; you do well. Even the demons believe, and shudder" (James 2:19). Read it in Greek and the point sharpens. The demons *pisteuousin*, the very same verb, but the construction is *pisteuō hoti*: believe THAT God is one. Their theology is flawless. Their content is correct. What they have is the proposition, held at a distance, and it makes them tremble because they know it is true and they refuse to move toward it. What the demons lack is not accuracy. What they lack is the *eis*.

The Gospel With No Noun

Here is a second detail hiding in plain sight. John's Gospel, the book written explicitly "that you may believe" (John 20:31), uses the verb *pisteuō* about 98 times. And the noun *pistis*, faith? Zero times. Not once in twenty-one chapters.

That cannot be an accident. For John, faith is never a possession you have. It is only ever an act you do. You will search his Gospel in vain for anyone who "has faith" as a kind of spiritual inventory item. There are only people believing, or refusing to. Faith in John is like breathing: it exists only in the doing of it.

The Hebrew: Planting Your Weight on Firm Ground

Now go back to the beginning, because the Old Testament was making this same point a millennium and a half earlier, in even more physical language.

The main Hebrew root for believing is א-מ-ן, *aman*, and its base picture is firmness. It describes solid ground, a pillar that bears weight, a peg driven into a sure place, the steady arms of a nurse carrying a child (Numbers 11:12). To believe, *he'emin*, is therefore not to entertain an idea. It is to plant your full weight on what will hold you.

The foundational verse of biblical faith uses exactly this word: "And Abram believed [*he'emin*] the LORD, and he counted it to him as righteousness" (Genesis 15:6). Abram, an old man under a night sky, put his whole weight on a promise, and then he moved his life accordingly, which is the only proof that weight has actually been transferred. The noun from this root is *emunah*, steadfastness, faithfulness, as in the verse that later shook the world: "the righteous shall live by his *emunah*" (Habakkuk 2:4).

Isaiah even built a pun on the root, a wordplay you can hear in the Hebrew: *im lo ta'aminu, ki lo te'amenu*, "if you will not stand firm in faith, you will not stand at all" (Isaiah 7:9). Believing and standing are the same root because they are the same act.

Alongside *aman* stands its companion *batach*, to trust in the sense of leaning on something, lying down secure upon it: "Trust [*batach*] in the LORD with all your heart, and lean not on your own understanding" (Proverbs 3:5). The Psalms are full of it: "When I am afraid, I put my trust in you" (Psalm 56:3). One word says the ground is solid; the other says go ahead and lean.

And here is the part you already know without realizing it. *Amen* is the same word. It comes straight from the root *aman*. Every time God's people say amen, they are not saying "the end" or "I agree in principle." They are performing the *aman* act, declaring: that is solid ground, and I put my weight there. This is why Jesus, alone among the teachers of Israel, prefaced his own sayings with "Amen, amen, I say to you." Rabbis said amen to the words of others. Jesus staked amen on his own words in advance, because he himself is the firm ground, "the Amen, the faithful and true witness" (Revelation 3:14).

The God Whose Name Is a Verb

Why is Scripture built this way? Why is its faith vocabulary all motion and weight and leaning, when the faith vocabulary of English has gone so still?

Part of the answer is that biblical Hebrew itself is a verb-driven language. Its sentences characteristically lead with the verb; its poetry moves in actions, not abstractions. But the deeper answer stands at the burning bush. When Moses asks God for his name, the answer

is not a noun. It is *ehyeh asher ehyeh*, "I AM WHO I AM" (Exodus 3:14), a first-person form of the verb *hayah*, "to be." And the covenant name itself, YHWH, appears to be built from that same verb of being. Every other god of the ancient world was named with a noun: storm, sun, sea, sky. The God of Israel named himself with an act of being. He is not a concept to be filed but a presence to be met.

A God whose very name is a verb cannot be related to by a noun. And that touches the reason for our existence in the first place. Scripture presents a relational God who created relational beings for relationship: "Let us make man in our image" (Genesis 1:26), and then a garden, and then a God who walks in it looking for the man (Genesis 3:8-9). Relationship, by its nature, requires action; anything else is passive and unintentional. It requires direction, a moving toward, which is what intentional commitment looks like. It is the same with love, and not by coincidence, for God is love (1 John 4:8). Love cannot be bestowed by force or extracted by demand; it must be chosen, and the choosing, carried out in motion, is the only way to show what is truly in a heart. This is why the greatest commandment is not "believe that God exists" but "love the LORD your God with all your heart and with all your soul and with all your might" (Deuteronomy 6:5). All, all, all: the language of transferred weight.

The Bridge Between the Testaments

Now watch the two Testaments join hands, because this connection is direct and documented, not a devotional flourish.

Centuries before Christ, when the Jewish translators of the Septuagint reached Genesis 15:6 and had to carry *he'emin*, Abram's weight-planting, into Greek, the word they chose was *episteusen*, from *pisteuō*. When Paul builds his great argument for justification by faith, he quotes that exact Greek rendering, in Romans 4:3 and again in Galatians 3:6. And Habakkuk's *emunah* verse, "the righteous shall live by faith," is quoted three times in the New Testament: Romans 1:17, Galatians 3:11, and Hebrews 10:38, each time carrying the Hebrew idea forward in the Greek word *pistis*.

So *pisteuō* is not a new Greek idea replacing an old Hebrew one. It is the appointed carrier of *aman* across the language barrier. The entrusting word was chosen, generations in advance, to bear the weight-planting word into the world.

And here is the detail that should quiet the old debate: James quotes Genesis 15:6 too. The apostle of "faith without works is dead" reaches for the very same verse as the apostle of "justified by faith apart from works" (James 2:23; Romans 4:3). Paul and James are not contradicting each other; they are guarding the same word from two different corruptions. Paul guards it against those who would turn faith into a wage, earned by labor. James guards it against those who would shrink faith into an armchair opinion. Both are defending *aman*, *pisteuō eis*, the entrusting motion of the whole person. Belief that never moves was

never belief into. Works that are not the movement of trust were never faith's works. The moment you recover the biblical word, the two apostles turn out to be standing back to back, facing opposite errors, defending one gate.

One Posture, Two Languages

Line everything up now, and the two Testaments are seen describing a single posture from four angles.

Aman: plant your weight on firm ground. *Batach*: lean on it with all your heart. *Nabat*: fix your eyes on it in expectant dependence, the way the dying Israelites in the wilderness gazed at the bronze serpent lifted up on the pole and lived (Numbers 21:9), the same gaze Zechariah promised would one day rest on the pierced One (Zechariah 12:10). *Pisteuō eis*: believe into him, fall toward him, transfer yourself out of your own keeping and into his.

Four words. One motion. And not one of them passive.

Jesus himself fused the wilderness gaze and the believing-into in a single breath: "As Moses lifted up the serpent in the wilderness, so must the Son of Man be lifted up, that whoever believes into him may have eternal life" (John 3:14-15). "Look and live" and "believe into him and live" are the same posture in two languages, one performed with the eyes, one with the whole self. The dying man in the desert did not contribute a work; he could not even stand. But neither did he merely hold an opinion about bronze. He turned. He fixed his eyes. He hung his last hope on what God had lifted up. That is what the word means.

What This Asks of Us

None of this is visible in a quick English reading, and so we go on debating a pale word the Bible never used. But the God of Scripture is not passive, and he has never once asked for passive belief. His name is a verb. His faith-words are weight and lean and gaze and fall. His own Son did not believe things about us from a distance; the Word became flesh and moved into the neighborhood, walked toward the cross, and entrusted himself to the Father through death itself (Luke 23:46; 1 Peter 2:23). He believed into the Father so that we could believe into him.

So the question the Bible actually asks is not "Do you agree that these things are true?" The demons could answer yes. The question is the one the wilderness asked a dying camp of snakebitten rebels: God has lifted up your cure. Will you turn your eyes and put your whole weight there?

Look, and live. Lean, and stand. Believe into him, and never be moved.

